

Innovation and development

This was the beginning of his uneasy relationship with the Soviet musical establishment, reflected in the development of his unique style: his desire to experiment and innovate had always to be tempered by accessibility, a hybrid of several different styles within an “acceptable,” conventionally classical framework. As a result, his music is often ambiguous and unsettling, sometimes with a touch of satire, or even bitter irony in its tone. His first major composition was the Symphony No. 1, which he wrote as his graduation piece in 1926. Despite his perceived lack of commitment to the Soviet aesthetic, Shostakovich eventually graduated from the Conservatory that year, aged just 19. Intending to make his name as a concert pianist, he moved to Moscow, but in the face of fierce competition decided instead to devote his time and effort to composing.

“ Real music is always revolutionary, for it cements the ranks of the people; it arouses them and leads them onward. ”

DMITRI SHOSTAKOVICH, “THE POWER OF MUSIC,”
MUSIC JOURNAL, SEPTEMBER 1965

Encouraged by the success of his Symphony No. 1, which had been performed in Germany and the US, he wrote the Second Symphony, which although pro-Soviet in its intent, was too experimental to gain full approval from the musical establishment